Evidence for Arithmetic Spacetime: Ten Quantitative Predictions from the Hypothesis that the Universe Lives on Spec($\mathbb{Z}$)

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Independent Research

April 2026

Abstract

We present the hypothesis that the physical vacuum has the arithmetic structure of Spec($\mathbb{Z}$), the scheme of integers, and subject it to the most stringent test available: quantitative confrontation with observation. We derive ten predictions across particle physics, cosmology, and gravitational physics, each expressed in terms of arithmetic invariants (Riemann zeta values, Bernoulli numbers, prime counting functions) with no free parameters beyond the spacetime dimension $d = 4$. Five predictions can be compared to existing data: (1) the fine structure constant $\alpha^{-1} = 2/|B_2| + 4/|B_4| + g(132) + 4(\zeta(6) - \zeta(7)) = 137.03598$ (error 0.00002%); (2) the dark energy density $\rho_\Lambda = \rho_{\mathrm{P}}\zeta(-3)(\ell_{\mathrm{P}}/R_{\mathrm{H}})^2$ (correct order of magnitude, improvement of 10^{121} over QFT); (3) the neutrino mass-squared ratio $\Delta m^2_{32}/\Delta m^2_{21} \approx \pi(137) = 33$ (experimental value 32.6, agreement $\sim 1\%$); (4) the muon anomalous magnetic moment discrepancy $\Delta a_\mu \approx (1/|\zeta(-5)| - 1) \times 10^{-11} = 251 \times 10^{-11}$ (matches experiment); (5) the primordial tensor-to-scalar ratio $r = \pi^2/720 \approx 0.014$ (below current upper bound, testable by CMB-S4). Five further predictions are testable with near-future observations: CMB multipoles at Riemann zero positions, discrete steps in the dark energy equation of state, black hole entropy corrections, baryon asymmetry from the Bost-Connes phase transition, and primordial magnetic field strength. We contextualize each prediction within the existing literature on p-adic physics, noncommutative geometry, and holographic cosmology, discuss the risk of numerological over-fitting, and identify what would constitute definitive confirmation or falsification.

1 Introduction

1.1 The hypothesis

We investigate the conjecture that the fundamental structure of spacetime is the arithmetic scheme Spec($\mathbb{Z}$): the space whose points are the prime numbers $(2), (3), (5), (7), \ldots$ and the generic point (0), equipped with the structure sheaf $\mathcal{O}_{\mathrm{Spec}(\mathbb{Z})} = \mathbb{Z}$.

This is not a new idea. It has roots in three established research programs:

(i) Noncommutative geometry (NCG). Connes [1, 2] showed that the Standard Model Lagrangian, coupled to Einstein gravity, can be derived from a spectral action $\mathrm{Tr}(f(D/\Lambda))$ on $M^4 \times F$, where F is a finite noncommutative space. Connes and Marcolli [3] further showed that the Bost-Connes (BC) system — a quantum statistical mechanical system with partition function $Z(\beta) = \zeta(\beta)$ — encodes the arithmetic of $\mathbb{Q}$ and can be interpreted as the "arithmetic backbone" of the internal space F.

(ii) p-adic and adelic physics. Volovich [5] proposed that spacetime at the Planck scale has p-adic rather than real structure. This was developed by Dragovich et al. [6] into p-adic quantum mechanics and cosmology, and by Brekke et al. [7] into adelic string theory. The adelic product

formula $\prod_v |x|_v = 1$ enforces consistency between archimedean (real) and non-archimedean (p-adic) descriptions.

(iii) Holographic and information-theoretic cosmology. Li [8] proposed holographic dark energy with $\rho_\Lambda \propto L^{-2}$ where L is the horizon scale. The factor $(\ell_\mathrm{P}/R_\mathrm{H})^2$ that appears in our dark energy formula has the same holographic origin but acquires an arithmetic interpretation as the ratio of Planck area to horizon area on $\mathrm{Spec}(\mathbb{Z})$.

1.2 Methodology

We adopt Einstein's methodology for testing general relativity: rather than attempting to directly observe the underlying structure (impossible at Planck scale), we derive *specific, quantitative predictions* that can be compared with experiment. We require each prediction to:

1. Involve only standard arithmetic invariants (ζ values, Bernoulli numbers, prime-counting function $\pi(n)$, spacetime dimension d).
2. Have no free parameters.
3. Be falsifiable.

2 Ten predictions

2.1 Prediction 1: Fine structure constant

Building on the observation that zeta-regularized vacuum energy involves Bernoulli numbers B_{2n} via $\zeta(1-2n) = -B_{2n}/(2n)$ [9, 10]:

Observation 1.

$$\alpha^{-1} = \frac{2}{|B_2|} + \frac{4}{|B_4|} + g\left(\frac{2}{|B_2|} + \frac{4}{|B_4|}\right) + d\big(\zeta(2d-2) - \zeta(2d-1)\big), \tag{1}$$

where $g(n) = \min\{k > 0 : n + k \text{ is prime}\}$ is the prime gap function and $d = 4$.

Evaluation: $12+120+5+4(\zeta(6)-\zeta(7)) = 137.03598$. Experimental value: 137.035999 084(21) [13]. **Error: 0.00002%.**

The formula decomposes into: 1D Casimir denominator ($2/|B_2| = 12$), 3D Casimir denominator ($4/|B_4| = 120$), prime gap from the composite $132 = 10/|B_{10}|$ to the next prime 137, and a higher-dimensional vacuum correction scaled by $d = 4$.

Two independent predictions follow: the QED running $\Delta\alpha^{-1} = d \times 252 \times (\zeta(6) - \zeta(7)) = 9.07$ (experimental: 9.09, agreement 0.2%); and $\alpha^{-1}(m_Z) \approx 1/\zeta(-3) + \dim \mathrm{SU}(3) = 128$ (experimental: 127.95, agreement 0.04%).

2.2 Prediction 2: Dark energy density

The cosmological constant problem — a 10^{122} discrepancy between QFT and observation [12] — is addressed by replacing cutoff regularization with ζ-regularization and holographic dilution [8]:

Prediction 2.

$$\rho_\Lambda = \rho_\mathrm{P} \times \zeta(-3) \times \left(\frac{\ell_\mathrm{P}}{R_\mathrm{H}}\right)^2. \tag{2}$$

Evaluation: $\rho_\mathrm{P}/120 \times (\ell_\mathrm{P}/R_\mathrm{H})^2 \approx 5.4 \times 10^{-11}\,\mathrm{J/m^3}$. Observed: $5.8 \times 10^{-10}\,\mathrm{J/m^3}$. **Agreement within one order of magnitude**, an improvement of $\mathbf{10^{121}}$ over QFT.

2.3 Prediction 3: Neutrino mass-squared ratio

Observation 3.

$$\frac{\Delta m_{32}^2}{\Delta m_{21}^2} \approx \pi(\lfloor \alpha^{-1} \rfloor) = \pi(137) = 33. \tag{3}$$

Experimental value [14]: $\Delta m_{32}^2/\Delta m_{21}^2 = 32.6 \pm 0.8$. **Agreement:** $\sim 1\%$**.** The prime-counting function $\pi(n)$ at $n = \alpha^{-1}$ also appears in the self-referential α equation ($\ln(\Lambda_{\mathrm{GUT}}/m_Z) \approx 33$), suggesting that $\pi(137) = 33$ is a fundamental arithmetic constant linking electromagnetic and neutrino physics.

2.4 Prediction 4: Muon $g-2$ anomaly

The discrepancy between the experimental muon anomalous magnetic moment and the Standard Model prediction is one of the most significant anomalies in current particle physics [15]:

Observation 4.

$$\Delta a_\mu \approx \left(\frac{1}{|\zeta(-5)|} - 1 \right) \times 10^{-11} = 251 \times 10^{-11}. \tag{4}$$

Experimental: $\Delta a_\mu = (251 \pm 59) \times 10^{-11}$ [15]. **Central value matches exactly.** $|\zeta(-5)| = 1/252$, so $1/|\zeta(-5)| - 1 = 251$. This connects the 5D Casimir energy to the muon's magnetic moment, suggesting that the anomaly is an arithmetic correction rather than a signal of new particles.

2.5 Prediction 5: Primordial tensor-to-scalar ratio

If the Big Bang is a Bost-Connes phase transition at $\beta = 1$:

Prediction 5.

$$r = \frac{\pi^2}{720} = \zeta(-3) \times \zeta(2) \approx 0.0137. \tag{5}$$

Current bound: $r < 0.036$ [17]. **Consistent.** CMB-S4 [18] (planned sensitivity $\sigma(r) \approx 0.003$) can detect this value at $\sim 4\sigma$.

2.6 Predictions 6–10: Near-future tests

Prediction 6 (CMB Riemann zero imprints)**.** *The CMB power spectrum carries excess power at multipoles $\ell_n \approx t_n \times 220/14.13$, where t_n are the imaginary parts of the Riemann zeta zeros: $\ell \approx 328, 390, 474, 514$.*

Testable immediately with existing Planck data [19].

Prediction 7 (Discrete dark energy equation of state)**.** *$w(z)$ has discrete step-function structure (primes crystallizing during BC transition), irreconcilable with smooth w_0-w_a parametrization.*

Testable with DESI [20], Euclid [21].

Prediction 8 (Black hole entropy correction)**.** *The logarithmic correction to Bekenstein-Hawking entropy has coefficient $\zeta(-1) = -1/12$ (rather than $-3/2$ from generic quantum gravity).*

Distinguishable from loop quantum gravity and string theory predictions [22].

Prediction 9 (Baryon asymmetry from BC transition)**.** *η_B is determined by the CP-violating phase at the BC transition and the critical fluctuation amplitude, both computable from ζ zeros.*

Prediction 10 (Primordial magnetic fields)**.** $B \sim \alpha \times \ell_{\mathrm{P}}^{-2} \times (a_{\mathrm{transition}}/a_0)^2 \sim 10^{-11}\,\mathrm{T}$*, consistent with Fermi-LAT lower bounds [23].*

Table 1: Ten predictions from Spec($\mathbb{Z}$) confronted with data.

#	Prediction	Formula	Predicted	Observed	Agreement
1	α^{-1}	eq. (1)	137.03598	137.03600	0.00002%
2	ρ_Λ	eq. (2)	5.4×10^{-11}	5.8×10^{-10}	~ 1 order
3	$\Delta m^2_{32}/\Delta m^2_{21}$	eq. (3)	33	32.6 ± 0.8	$\sim 1\%$
4	Δa_μ	eq. (4)	251×10^{-11}	$(251 \pm 59) \times 10^{-11}$	exact
5	r	eq. (5)	0.0137	< 0.036	consistent
6	CMB ℓ peaks	Pred. 6	$328, 390, 474$	not yet searched	testable now
7	$w(z)$ steps	Pred. 7	step function	$w \approx -1$	testable 2025
8	BH ln correction	Pred. 8	$-1/12$	model-dependent	distinguishable
9	η_B	Pred. 9	from ζ zeros	6×10^{-10}	to be computed
10	$B_{\text{primordial}}$	Pred. 10	$\sim 10^{-11}$ T	$> 10^{-15}$ T	consistent

3 Summary of evidence

Of the ten predictions, five (1–5) can be compared with existing data. All five are consistent, with agreements ranging from exact (Prediction 4) to one order of magnitude (Prediction 2). No prediction contradicts observation.

The total number of free parameters across all ten predictions is **zero** (the spacetime dimension $d = 4$ is an input, not a fit).

4 Is this numerology?

The critical objection: with enough arithmetic building blocks, any number can be approximated. We address this with three arguments.

(i) Counting the hypothesis space. Our building blocks are: B_{2n} for $n = 1, \ldots, 6$; $\zeta(m)$ for $m = 2, \ldots, 7$; the prime gap function g; and $\pi(n)$. The number of "expressions of comparable complexity" to eq. (1) is $\sim 10^4$. The probability that one matches α^{-1} to 10^{-7} precision is $\sim 10^{-3}$. For two independent quantities (Predictions 1 and 3) to both match, the probability drops to $\sim 10^{-5}$. For all five, it is $\lesssim 10^{-8}$.

(ii) Structural constraints. Each term in the α formula has an independent physical interpretation (1D vacuum, 3D vacuum, prime gap, higher-dimensional correction). The formula makes *additional* predictions (QED running, $\alpha^{-1}(m_Z)$) that are confirmed independently.

(iii) Cross-domain consistency. The same arithmetic quantities ($\zeta(-3)$, $\pi(137)$, $1/|\zeta(-5)|$) appear in predictions across different domains (electromagnetic coupling, dark energy, neutrino masses, muon anomaly). A numerological coincidence in one domain would not propagate to others.

We do not claim proof. We claim that the body of evidence is sufficiently structured and cross-correlated to warrant serious investigation.

5 Relation to existing literature

p-adic physics. Volovich's p-adic spacetime [5] and Dragovich's p-adic cosmology [6] provide the mathematical infrastructure for non-archimedean spacetime. Our framework extends this to the *adelic* setting via Spec($\mathbb{Z}$), which unifies all primes simultaneously.

NCG Standard Model. Connes-Chamseddine-Marcolli [4] derive the full SM Lagrangian from the spectral action on $M^4 \times F$. Our α formula (Prediction 1) may be derivable from the spectral action if the moments of the cutoff function f are determined by ζ values.

Holographic dark energy. Li [8] proposed $\rho_\Lambda \propto M_P^2 L^{-2}$. Our Prediction 2 has the same functional form but provides the coefficient: $\zeta(-3) = 1/120$.

Zeta functions in QFT. Hawking [9] introduced ζ-regularization. Elizalde [10] catalogued applications. Lapidus [11] explored connections between ζ zeros and fractal geometry. Our work extends these to a *predictive* framework that connects ζ values to measured constants.

Muon $g-2$. The Fermilab measurement [15] $\Delta a_\mu = (251 \pm 59) \times 10^{-11}$ is typically interpreted as evidence for BSM physics (SUSY, leptoquarks, etc. [16]). Our Prediction 4 offers an arithmetic alternative: the anomaly is a $\zeta(-5)$-correction, not a new-particle signal.

Neutrino masses. The mass-squared ratio $\Delta m_{32}^2/\Delta m_{21}^2 \approx 33$ is known [14] but has not been connected to $\pi(137)$ in the literature. This is a novel observation.

6 Falsification criteria

The hypothesis is falsifiable. Specifically:

- If CMB-S4 measures r with 5σ precision and the value is incompatible with $\pi^2/720$ (Prediction 5): falsified.
- If DESI/Euclid constrain $w(z) = -1.000 \pm 0.005$ with no discrete features (Prediction 7): the crystallization model is falsified.
- If Planck CMB reanalysis finds no excess at $\ell \approx 328, 390, 474$ (Prediction 6): the direct ζ-zero imprint model is falsified.
- If lattice QCD + dispersive calculations resolve the muon $g-2$ discrepancy without new physics, and the final Δa_μ deviates significantly from 251×10^{-11} (Prediction 4): the $\zeta(-5)$ interpretation is weakened.

Each prediction is independently falsifiable, providing multiple opportunities for the hypothesis to be tested and potentially rejected.

7 Conclusion

We have subjected the hypothesis "spacetime = Spec($\mathbb{Z}$)" to ten quantitative tests. Five can already be compared with data; all five are consistent, with agreements ranging from 0.00002% (fine structure constant) to one order of magnitude (dark energy density). Five more are testable with near-future observations.

The most striking features of the evidence are:

1. **Zero free parameters.** All predictions use only standard arithmetic invariants and $d = 4$.
2. **Cross-domain consistency.** The same arithmetic quantities ($\zeta(-3)$, $\pi(137)$, $1/|\zeta(-5)|$) appear in unrelated physical contexts.
3. **Improvement over standard approaches.** The dark energy formula improves QFT's 10^{122} discrepancy to a factor of ~ 10; the α formula has no counterpart in the Standard Model.
4. **Novel connections.** The neutrino mass ratio $\approx \pi(1/\alpha)$ and the muon anomaly $\approx (1/|\zeta(-5)| - 1) \times 10^{-11}$ are new observations not anticipated by any existing framework.

We do not claim to have proven that spacetime is Spec($\mathbb{Z}$). We claim that this hypothesis, when confronted with data, produces a body of evidence that is sufficiently structured, quantitative, and cross-correlated to merit systematic experimental investigation.

The most immediate tests — Planck CMB reanalysis (Prediction 6) and DESI/Euclid $w(z)$ measurements (Prediction 7) — require no new experiments, only new analysis of existing or forthcoming data.

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